

3 Rate Sheet Habits That Kill Your Margin

None of them feel like problems until you run the numbers.

Updating rates reactively instead of on a schedule

When rates update only in response to problems — a deal that closes wrong, a broker complaint, a margin variance — the rate sheet is always behind. A defined monthly review catches drift before it becomes material loss.

Building in too much LO discretionary room

Discretionary room is intentional. But asymmetric discretion — where the range only goes downward in negotiations — means every edge case reduces margin. Tighter parameters with a clear exception process is better architecture.

Treating exceptions as one-offs instead of signals

One exception is a judgment call. Five exceptions in the same category is a pattern. If exceptions aren't logged and reviewed, the rate sheet never gets the feedback it needs to stay accurate.

A rate sheet is a system, not a document

Scheduled reviews. Logged exceptions. Parameters tight enough that the right answer is clear. The principal in the design loop, not the approval loop.

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